

BRUTE OF THE MATTER

The upcoming middleweight duel between former champion Robert Whittaker and rising star Ikram Aliskerov promises to be an **electrifying showdown.**

Nigamanth P

nigamanth.p@thehindu.co.in

With a middleweight main event that might have title ramifications and interesting supporting acts all around, the UFC (Ultimate Fighting Championship) Fight Night on June 23 promises to be a blockbuster.

Restructured only last week, the main event between Robert Whittaker and Ikram Aliskerov is an engrossing pairing of a former champion and a rising star.

Whittaker, who was initially scheduled to fight Khamzat Chimaev, defeated Paulo Costa via unanimous decision earlier this year to bounce back from his defeat to current champion Dricus Du Plessis at UFC 290.

Aliskerov was a couple of days away from stepping in with newcomer Antonio Trocoli in Las Vegas before he was selected to fill in opposite Whittaker.

The 31-year-old from Dana White's Contender Series has blown through his first two UFC opponents without much trouble and is gearing up to face his biggest test yet.

Aliskerov, another talented grappler from Dagestan, although just two fights into his UFC career, has showcased top-notch

Power moves: Robert Whittaker's (R) experience, coupled with powerful striking and movement, gives him an edge over Ikram Aliskerov. AFP

wrestling and submission skills that allow him to control his opponents on the ground.

However, Whittaker poses a different threat than Aliskerov's other two opponents. His experience, coupled with powerful striking and movement, gives Whittaker an edge.

The Australian also possesses excellent takedown defence and can potentially shut down any advances from Aliskerov.

Meanwhile, Sergei Pavlovich and Alexander Volkov meet in a matchup of Russian heavyweight finishers and occasional training partners.

Pavlovich competes for the first time since being forced into an interim title fight against Tom Aspinall at Madison Square Garden in November.